

Read Your Own Bible Carefully

The divine identity of Christ, argued entirely from the New World Translation and the Kingdom Interlinear.

This document does one thing. It takes passages you already have, in the translation you already use, and asks what they say.

Nothing here asks you to trust a scholar, a website or a church. Every reference is given in full, with the edition where the edition matters, and the Greek — where there is any — is quoted from the *Kingdom Interlinear*, so that you can check it in your own copy rather than in ours. Where a passage is genuinely disputed, that is said. Where the strongest form of an argument depends on something you cannot check unaided, that is said too, and you are told exactly where the evidence sits.

Each section is built the same way. A question at the top. Then the reading: the verses, what comes before and after them, and what the writer is arguing across the whole passage — because a verse pulled out of its paragraph proves nothing, and you have met enough of that from both directions. Then a bordered box with the technical material: the Greek, the manuscripts, and the Watchtower's own published answer, stated as they state it, with our response to it.

The boxes are an offer rather than a requirement. If Greek means nothing to you, skip them; the argument above each one is written to stand without it.

You can stop at the end of any section. Three of them are marked as resting points, and the document is written so that stopping there costs you nothing.

At the end there is a list of arguments we considered and decided not to use, with the reason each was dropped. That list is there because a case that shows you only its best material is not a case, it is a sales pitch.

PART ONE

Who is Jesus, in your own Bible?

*Ten passages that ask nothing of you but to read
English carefully.*

Who is coming quickly?

Revelation ends with an epilogue running from 22:6 to the last verse. In it an angel speaks, John speaks, and a voice speaks that claims things no angel claims.

At 22:12 that voice says it is coming quickly, and that it brings its reward with it, to render to each one according to his work. At 22:13 the same voice gives itself three titles: the Alpha and the Omega, the first and the last, the beginning and the end. Then at 22:16, with no change of speaker marked in between, the voice says: I, Jesus, sent my angel to bear witness to you about these things.

The Watchtower assigns verse 13 to Jehovah, and the published reason is that the speaker there is not identified. That is the part worth testing, because the speaker identifies himself three verses later.

The pattern repeats at the end of the chapter. At 22:20 the voice says again that it is coming quickly, and John answers it by name: Amen, come, Lord Jesus.

So read 22:12 to 22:16 as one passage, which is how it is printed in your Bible, and ask the simplest question available.

THE EVIDENCE

At 22:13 the Greek is ὁ πρῶτος καὶ ὁ ἔσχατος (*ho prōtos kai ho eschatos*) — both titles carry the definite article.

Their answer. *Revelation — Its Grand Climax at Hand!* assigns 22:13 to Jehovah on the ground that the speaker is unnamed there, and elsewhere the Society has argued from the presence or absence of the Greek article that a title so marked belongs to God alone. A second answer holds that Jesus may be called first and last in a different sense: first raised to immortal spirit life, and the last so raised directly by Jehovah.

Response. The article argument cannot do this work here, because 22:13 is articular and they assign it to Jehovah anyway — so the presence of the article is not what is deciding the question. The resurrection-order explanation has no support in any text: no passage anywhere describes the title that way, and it is supplied to fit the difficulty rather than drawn from anything written.

ARGUMENT TWO

What does “the first and the last” mean when Isaiah uses it?

Isaiah 44:6 sits inside a courtroom speech. From 44:6 to 44:8 Jehovah is challenging the gods of the nations to produce evidence, and the title arrives bolted to an exclusivity clause: he is the first and the last, and besides him there is no God. At 48:12 he says it again to Israel, in a passage about who called the heavens into being.

The title is not decorative. In Isaiah it is a claim about how many there are.

Now turn to Revelation 1:17-18. John falls down as dead, and the one standing over him says: I am the First and the Last, and the living one. He adds that he became dead and is alive forever. At 2:8 the letter to Smyrna opens with the same title and identifies its speaker as the one who became dead and came to life. Neither place is ambiguous about who that is.

Then return to 22:13, where the title appears a third time, in the passage you have just read.

One caution, because it matters and because you will check it. The argument is not that the Greek of Revelation copies the Greek of Isaiah word for word. It does not, and anyone who tells you otherwise is handing you something that will fall apart. The argument is that Isaiah’s title carries an exclusivity clause with it, and John gives that title to Jesus three times in one book.

THE EVIDENCE

Both Septuagint readings are worth knowing, because they are where a verbal-quotation claim collapses. Isaiah 44:6 reads ἐγὼ πρῶτος καὶ ἐγὼ μετὰ ταῦτα (*egō prōtos kai egō meta tauta*), “I am first and I am after these things.” Isaiah 48:12 does not contain a word for “last” at all. John is rendering the Hebrew *rishon* and *acharon* directly rather than quoting the Greek.

Their answer. The title applies to both, but means different things in each case — of Jehovah, that there is no God before or after him; of Jesus, a priority in resurrection.

Response. Isaiah does not leave the sense open: the clause attached to the title in 44:6 is the reason the title is being used. And a title that means uniqueness of deity in one book and order of resurrection in another needs some textual warrant for the second meaning. There is none.

Who was speaking to Isaiah?

Isaiah 6 is the temple vision. Isaiah sees the throne, hears the seraphs, is cleansed, and then at 6:8 hears Jehovah ask whom he should send. Isaiah answers, and 6:9–10 is the message he is given: this people's heart is to grow unreceptive, their ears unresponsive, their eyes pasted shut.

Those two verses — 6:9 and 6:10, not 6:8 — are the ones the New Testament quotes.

Turn to Acts 28:25. Paul is in Rome, the Jewish leaders are leaving, and as they go he quotes exactly that message. His introduction to it is the point: he says the holy spirit spoke it, through Isaiah, to their forefathers.

Now John 12. From 12:37 John is explaining why people did not believe in Jesus despite the signs. He quotes Isaiah twice, the second time from 6:10. Then at 12:41 he writes that Isaiah said these things because he saw his glory, and spoke about him.

Be careful here, because your Bible is careful here. The New World Translation leaves that pronoun unspecified, where several other translations supply “Jesus.” So the argument cannot be made from the wording. It has to be made from the run of the passage: the one they were not believing in at verse 37, the one Isaiah spoke about at verse 41, the one the rulers put faith in at verse 42. That sequence is unbroken and it is about Jesus. The references to the Father in this chapter sit at 12:26 and 12:44–50, outside it.

One speech, in one chapter of Isaiah. Jehovah spoke it. The holy spirit spoke it. And the glory Isaiah saw while hearing it belonged to the one John has been describing for five verses.

THE EVIDENCE

The same move is made twice more in Hebrews. At 3:7 the writer introduces Psalm 95 with the words that the holy spirit says, and what follows is God speaking in the first person. At 10:15-17 he does it with Jeremiah 31 — treated in full in Part Two.

Their answer. The pronoun at John 12:41 is not specified in the Greek, and John 12 speaks of the Father at 12:26, 12:28 and 12:49-50, so “his glory” may be the Father’s glory rather than Christ’s.

Response. That is correct about the pronoun, which is why the argument is not made from it. It is made from 12:37-42, where the subject does not change: the same person is not believed in at 37, spoken about by Isaiah at 41, and believed in by the rulers at 42. The Father appears in this chapter before and after that sequence, not inside it. Note also that Acts 28:25 is untouched by any of this: the speech Isaiah heard from Jehovah is credited to the holy spirit with no pronoun to dispute.

Who was with him?

This one is a hinge, so it is worth reading slowly.

Isaiah 44:24 sits in an oracle about Cyrus and the rebuilding of Jerusalem, running from 44:24 to the end of the chapter. It opens with Jehovah identifying himself as the redeemer and the former of his people, and then makes a claim about creation in the form of a question. He stretched out the heavens by himself. He spread out the earth — and then: who was with me?

It is a rhetorical question, and it is asked in order to exclude something. Not to exclude idols, which cannot make anything, but to exclude help.

Now Hebrews 1. From verse 5 the writer is stacking quotations to show that the Son is not in the same category as the angels. At 1:10–12 he quotes Psalm 102:25–27 and applies it to the Son: you at the beginning laid the foundations of the earth, and the heavens are the works of your hands; they will perish, but you remain.

Look up Psalm 102 in your own Bible and see who is being addressed. It is a prayer, and it is addressed to Jehovah. Hebrews takes those words and speaks them to the Son.

Hold this one, because it comes back. When you reach the argument about Colossians, the question at Isaiah 44:24 is the one that has to be answered.

THE EVIDENCE

The New World Translation prints “O Lord” at Hebrews 1:10, where the Greek has κύριε (*kyrie*); the psalm as they render it in the Hebrew Scriptures addresses Jehovah.

Their answer. Creation through an agent is not excluded, because Proverbs 8:22–30 presents wisdom beside God as a master worker, and the Son is identified with that figure. Isaiah 44:24 then denies help from anyone outside that arrangement rather than denying an agent within it.

Response. The weight sits on one contested word in a contested passage. The Hebrew צִמְּסָא (*amon*) at Proverbs 8:30 is disputed between “craftsman” and “nursling”; the speaker throughout Proverbs 8 is personified Wisdom, presented as a woman; and the New World Translation renders her pronouns neuter, which is what permits the identification. That is a great deal of structure to build on a figure of speech, in order to answer a question Isaiah asks in plain terms.

Why does Isaiah use the same title twice?

Isaiah 9:6 is the child passage. A child is born, the government rests on his shoulder, and he is given four titles. One of them is Mighty God.

Two chapters later, at Isaiah 10:21, a remnant returns — and the one it returns to is called the Mighty God. Same title, same prophet, same short stretch of text.

You do not have to take our word for the link. Look at the footnote in your own Bible at 10:21. It gives the Hebrew behind the title and refers you back to the footnote at 9:6. The connection is made by your own translation's apparatus.

The context in both places is worth checking, because it is the obvious place to look for an escape. Isaiah 9:1–7 is about a deliverance and the child who brings it; the titles are given to him, not to someone standing nearby. Isaiah 10:20–23 is about the survivors of Israel leaning on Jehovah in truth rather than on the one who struck them; the title there is unmistakably his.

The usual answer is that Mighty God is a lesser thing than Almighty God, and that the two titles are not the same. That answer is worth taking seriously, and the box takes it seriously. But it has to survive one observation first: Isaiah, in these two chapters, does not appear to observe the distinction.

THE EVIDENCE

The phrase is **אל גִּבּוֹר** (*El Gibbor*). In the singular and without the article it occurs in the Hebrew Bible only at Isaiah 9:6 and 10:21. Ezekiel 32:21 is not a parallel: it has a plural construct form, *elei gibborim*. The articular forms at Deuteronomy 10:17, Jeremiah 32:18 and Nehemiah 9:32 are all used of God.

Their answer. Mighty is not Almighty; the Hebrew Scriptures reserve *El Shaddai* and the Almighty language for Jehovah. A further argument appeals to the Greek: the Old Greek of Isaiah 9:6 does not render the four titles at all, collapsing them into **μεγάλης βουλῆς ἄγγελος** (*megalēs boulēs angelos*), “Messenger of Great Counsel.”

Response. The Hebrew is the original, and the Old Greek of Isaiah is a famously free translation that visibly struggles with this verse. The Great Isaiah Scroll from Qumran — older than any Septuagint manuscript we possess — reads with the Masoretic Text here, so the four titles are not a late development. And the later Greek versions correct back to the Hebrew: Eusebius records Aquila rendering the titles literally. On the lexical point, the objection would carry more weight if Isaiah himself kept the two titles apart. Two chapters is a short distance.

To whom is the knee bent?

Isaiah 45 contains one of the strongest statements of exclusivity in the Hebrew Scriptures. From 45:20 Jehovah is addressing the escaped ones of the nations. He says there is no other God besides him, tells them to turn to him and be saved, and then at 45:23 swears by himself that to him every knee will bend and every tongue will swear.

That is an oath, sworn by God on his own name, about what will be given to him and to no one else.

Now Philippians 2. The passage runs from 2:5 to 2:11 and it is one movement: Christ humbling himself, becoming obedient as far as death, and then being exalted. At 2:9 God gives him the name above every name. At 2:10–11 the purpose is stated — that in the name of Jesus every knee should bend, of those in heaven and on earth and under the ground, and every tongue acknowledge that Jesus Christ is Lord.

Two things belong in the open. Your Bible reads “in the name of Jesus” rather than “at the name,” and the passage ends by saying that all of this is to the glory of God the Father. Neither is hidden and neither is a difficulty for the question being asked.

The question is narrower than it looks. Paul has taken the words of an oath in which Jehovah says the knee bends to him, and has written them about Jesus, in a passage whose entire subject is the honour Jesus receives.

THE EVIDENCE

Their answer. The published study note explains that bending the knee in the name of Jesus means recognising his position and submitting to the authority given him, and points to Matthew 28:19 and Romans 10:9. The closing clause is decisive for them: the whole scene resolves to the glory of God the Father, which distinguishes the two.

Response. Recognising delegated authority is a natural reading of a great many passages, but Isaiah 45:23 is not one that leaves room for it, because the oath is sworn precisely to exclude anyone else receiving what is described. Note also Romans 14:11, where Paul quotes the same Isaiah verse and applies it to God — the same apostle, the same text, used both ways. That is the thing to explain.

Whose description is this?

Daniel 7:9-14 is a throne-room vision with two figures in it, and it is important to say at the outset that they are two. That is not in dispute here.

The first is the Ancient of Days. He takes his seat, his clothing is white as snow, and the hair of his head is like clean wool. The second appears at 7:13: one like a son of man, coming with the clouds of heaven, who is brought before the Ancient of Days and given rulership.

Now Revelation 1:12-16. John turns and sees someone among the lampstands, and describes him in this order: one like a son of man — Daniel's phrase, from Daniel 7:13 — and then his head and his hair white like white wool, like snow.

That second description is not the son of man's in Daniel. It is the Ancient of Days'.

So John is reading Daniel 7 as he writes; the borrowed phrase in the first clause establishes that much. And having borrowed the son of man from one figure, he goes straight on to describe him in the words Daniel used for the other.

This is an argument from allusion, and allusion is softer than quotation. It does not stand alone and it is not asked to. It sits beside the shared titles you have already seen, and it asks a question about a writer's choice: of all the ways to describe the glorified Christ, why this one?

THE EVIDENCE

Their answer. *Revelation — Its Grand Climax at Hand!*, in the chapter on John beholding the glorified Jesus, explains the white hair as indicating wisdom that comes with length of life, comparing Proverbs 16:31 on grey hair as a crown of beauty. Daniel 7:9 is not mentioned in that discussion.

Response. Proverbs 16:31 describes an ageing human being, which is a strange source for the appearance of a glorified spirit. The nearer source is in the same sentence John is writing: he has just used Daniel 7:13. A reader who knows Daniel — and John's first readers did — meets the son of man and the Ancient of Days' description in a single breath.

The same pattern recurs at Revelation 22:1 and 22:3, where one throne is called the throne of God and of the Lamb, and the servants of that throne render sacred service to *him*, singular.

Why is one greeting different from the rest of the letter?

Second Peter is three chapters long. Five times in it, the writer uses the same construction to speak of Jesus.

Four of them are rendered the same way in your Bible: our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ, at 1:11, at 2:20, at 3:2 and at 3:18. Nobody reads those as describing two people. They describe one person under two titles.

The fifth is the opening line, 1:1. There the construction is identical, and there it is rendered as though it named two: our God and the Savior Jesus Christ.

You cannot check that identity of construction from the English, and it would be dishonest to pretend you could. What you can do is look at all five in the *Kingdom Interlinear* and read the word-for-word line under each. The box sets out what you will find.

The context of 1:1 is a greeting, and greetings do sometimes distinguish God from Christ — verse 2, the very next line, does exactly that. So the question is not whether Peter ever distinguishes them. He does, constantly. The question is why one construction, used five times in three chapters, is translated one way four times and another way once.

THE EVIDENCE

The construction is an article, a noun, καί (*kai*), and a second noun with no article of its own. Where both nouns are singular, personal, and not proper names, the two describe one person. That is the rule as it is actually stated, and the qualifications matter.

Their answer. Appendix 2E of the 1985 *Kingdom Interlinear*, printed as Appendix 6E in the 1984 Reference Bible, argues that one article can govern two distinct persons, and points to 2 Peter 1:2, where God and Jesus are plainly distinguished in the very next verse. It lists parallels including Acts 13:50, Ephesians 5:5, 2 Thessalonians 1:12, 1 Timothy 5:21 and 6:13, and 2 Timothy 4:1, and quotes Ezra Abbot at length.

Response. The listed parallels do not meet the conditions of the rule: they involve plural nouns, or proper names, or both. And the appeal to verse 2 is a contextual argument rather than a grammatical one — which is precisely what the rest of the letter answers, since 1:11, 2:20, 3:2 and 3:18 place the same construction in the same short letter and are rendered of one person. Notice too what their own appendix prints: Abbot concedes that the phrase, taken by itself, would most naturally be understood of a single subject.

Where did “other” come from?

Colossians 1:15–20 is one continuous argument, and it has to be read whole or not at all.

Paul calls Christ the image of the invisible God and the firstborn of all creation. Then he gives his reason — because by means of him all things were created, in the heavens and on the earth, visible and invisible. He says all things have been created through him and for him, that he is before all things, and that by means of him all things were made to exist. Then he turns to the resurrection and calls him the firstborn from the dead.

Two things follow from reading it whole. First, “firstborn” here is a rank rather than a birth order: Psalm 89:27 calls David the firstborn, the highest of the kings of the earth, and David was his father’s youngest son. Second, the word “because” at the start of verse 16 makes the creating the ground of the title. He is firstborn precisely because everything was created in him.

Now the exhibit. In the *Kingdom Interlinear* the line printed under the Greek is the Society’s own word-for-word rendering. It reads “the all (things).” The New World Translation column beside it reads “all [other] things.”

πάσης of all	κτίσεως, 16 creation,	ὅτι because	ἐν in	αὐτῷ him	born of all creation; 16 because by means
ἐκτίσθη it was created	τὰ πάντα the all (things)	ἐν τοῖς in the	οὐρανοῖς heavens		of him all [other]
καὶ ἐπὶ τῆς γῆς, and upon the earth,	τὰ ὀρατὰ the (things) visible	καὶ and			upon the earth, the
τὰ ἀόρατα, the (things) invisible,	εἴτε θρόνοι whether thrones	εἴτε or			things visible and the
κυριότητες lordships	εἴτε ἀρχαὶ or governments	εἴτε ἐξουσίαι or authorities;			things invisible, no
τὰ πάντα the all (things)	δι' αὐτοῦ through him	καὶ εἰς αὐτόν and into him			matter whether they
ἐκτίσται· are created	17 καὶ αὐτὸς ἔστιν and he is	πρὸ before			are thrones or lord- ships or governments or authorities. All [other] things have

The Kingdom Interlinear Translation of the Greek Scriptures, Watch Tower Bible and Tract Society, 1969, p. 896, at Colossians 1:16. The word-for-word line reads “the all (things)”; the column beside it reads “all [other] things.” The brackets stand in the 1969 and 1984 editions and are absent from the 2013 revision, so the supplied word now reads as text. Reproduced for criticism and review.

THE EVIDENCE

Greek had the words. ἄλλος (*allos*), another of the same kind, and ἕτερος (*heteros*), another of a different kind, were both available to Paul. He used neither.

Their answer. The study note on Colossians 1:16 argues that although the Son was involved in creating, Scripture never calls him the Creator, and routes the point through Revelation 3:14 and through Proverbs 8:22–30, where wisdom is Jehovah’s master worker. Two further defences circulate: that the verb is passive, which suits an agent rather than a creator; and that “all things” sometimes needs limiting from context, as at 1 Corinthians 15:27.

Response. Set their note beside their verse: the note describes the Son as involved in the creation of all things, while the translation of the verse reads all *other* things. On the passive: a passive verb says nothing about whether the agent belongs inside the class created, which is the only question at issue. On *ta panta*: at 1 Corinthians 15:27 the limitation is stated in the text itself, in the next clause. Here nothing excludes the Son, and supplying a word that reverses a passage’s conclusion is not clarification.

And recall Isaiah 44:24. Creation carried out through an agent is exactly what that question was asked to rule out.

Who is Paul asking?

The Witness position on prayer is clear and consistent: prayer belongs to Jehovah, and Christians approach him through Jesus. So the interesting cases are the ones where someone speaks directly to Jesus.

The best known is Acts 7:59–60, where Stephen, being stoned, asks the Lord Jesus to receive his spirit. There is a published answer to that one and it is a reasonable answer: Stephen was at that moment seeing Jesus in vision, and speaking to someone you can see is not the same as praying. It is stated in full in the box.

So set Stephen aside and look at 2 Corinthians 12:8–9.

The passage runs from 12:1. Paul describes a vision he had fourteen years earlier, then describes the thorn in his flesh, given so that he would not be overexalted. About that thorn he says he entreated the Lord three times that it might depart. And he received an answer: undeserved kindness is sufficient, power is made perfect in weakness. Paul then says he will boast about his weaknesses so that the power of the Christ may remain over him.

There is no vision here. There is a man with a chronic affliction, asking repeatedly over time, and receiving a reply. The one he asked is the one whose power he says now rests on him.

Two more, briefly, because they run the same way. Paul opens 1 Corinthians by describing Christians as those who call on the name of our Lord Jesus Christ. And he closes 2 Corinthians, one chapter after the thorn, with the undeserved kindness of

the Lord Jesus Christ, the love of God, and the sharing in the holy spirit.

THE EVIDENCE

Their answer. *Insight on the Scriptures*, under “Prayer,” acknowledges that words are addressed to Jesus and explains the cases as exceptional: Stephen was seeing a vision of Jesus at that moment, as John was at Revelation 22:20 and Saul at Acts 9:4–5. Speaking to someone visibly present is not prayer. The New World Translation supports the distinction by rendering Acts 7:59 as an appeal rather than as prayer.

Response. Taken on its own terms, that answer covers Acts 7:59 and it should be granted. It does not reach 2 Corinthians 12:8–9, where there is no vision in view, the asking is repeated over time, and the answer comes from the one asked. Nor does it reach 1 Corinthians 1:2, where calling on the name of the Lord Jesus is simply what Christians are described as doing.

A resting point

That is the first section, and it is a reasonable place to stop.

Everything in it was in English, in your own Bible, and most of it inside a single chapter or a single short letter. No part of it depended on knowing Greek, and no part of it depended on believing anything about the men who produced your translation.

What it showed, put plainly: a voice in Revelation says it is coming quickly and then names itself Jesus; a title Isaiah attaches to an exclusivity claim is given to Jesus three times in one book; one speech in Isaiah 6 is credited to Jehovah and to the holy spirit; a psalm addressed to Jehovah is spoken to the Son in Hebrews; the same rare title is used of the child and of Jehovah two chapters apart, with your own footnote linking them; an oath Jehovah swore about the bending of every knee is written by Paul about Jesus; and Paul, with no vision in front of him, asked the Lord Jesus three times for something and was answered.

That is a lot to sit with, and there is no reason to do it quickly. The next section can wait as long as you want it to.

PART ONE, CONTINUED

Four questions about wording

*Where the argument turns on how a word has
been translated rather than on what it says.*

Why is the same phrase translated three different ways?

There is a short phrase in Hebrew that God uses about himself in Deuteronomy and Isaiah. It is two plain words, and it is one of the more distinctive things he says. In your Bible it comes out three different ways.

PASSAGE	SPEAKER	NEW WORLD TRANSLATION, 2013
Deuteronomy 32:39	Jehovah	I am he
Isaiah 43:10	Jehovah	I am the same One
Isaiah 46:4	Jehovah	I am the same One
Isaiah 48:12	Jehovah	I am the same One
John 8:24	Jesus	I am the one
John 8:28	Jesus	I am he
John 13:19	Jesus	I am he
John 18:5-8	Jesus	I am he

What the table shows needs stating carefully, because the strong version of this claim is not defensible and would not survive your checking it. It does not show a scheme. A scheme would not have produced “I am the one” at John 8:24, which helps nobody.

What it shows is an effect. Set John 13:18-19 beside Isaiah 43:10. In Isaiah, God addresses witnesses he has chosen, and says he has chosen them so that they may know and have faith in him and understand that he is the one. In John, Jesus says

he knows whom he has chosen, and tells them what will happen before it happens, so that when it happens they may believe that he is he. Same chosen-ones setting, same purpose, same closing phrase.

The link is there in the text. The rendering makes it invisible to anyone reading only this translation.

THE EVIDENCE

The Hebrew is אני הוּא (*ani hu*), literally “I he.” The Septuagint renders it ἐγὼ εἰμι (*egō eimi*), and that is the phrase John places on Jesus’ lips in all four passages above.

Their answer. There is no published defence of these renderings as such. The Society’s material in this area addresses John 8:58 and the rendering “I have been,” which is a separate dispute about tense and is not used in this document.

Response. Since no answer has been published, the fair thing is to state the one a Witness would give at a door: Hebrew and Greek idioms do not map onto single English phrases, and translators render idiomatically rather than mechanically. That is true, and it is why the claim here is limited to effect rather than intent. The effect stands either way: a translation that renders one idiom three ways conceals from its own readers a link that translations it dismisses preserve.

What happens to Paul's argument at Romans 10:13?

Your Bible uses the divine name 237 times in the Christian Greek Scriptures. That figure is not an outside estimate; it is stated in the translation's own appendix.

Two further details come from the same apparatus. The 1985 Reference Bible notes a further seventy-two places where the name appears only in the marginal readings. And the appendix concedes that one of the 237 — 1 Corinthians 7:17 — has no support from the Hebrew versions at all, and rests instead on context and related texts.

Now Romans 10. Read verses 9 to 14 as one argument, because that is what they are. Verse 9: if you declare publicly that Jesus is Lord and exercise faith that God raised him up, you will be saved. Verses 11 and 12: there is no distinction between Jew and Greek, for the same Lord is rich toward all who call on him. Verse 13: everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved — quoting Joel. Verse 14: how will they call on him whom they have not believed in?

Paul is building one chain, and the same word runs through it: declare Jesus Lord, call on the Lord, believe in the one you call on.

Your Bible breaks that chain at verse 13 by putting a different name into the middle of it. The published reason is straightforward and worth stating: Joel used the divine name, so the quotation should carry it. But the effect is that the one Paul tells you to confess in verse 9 and the one he tells you to call on in verse 13 are no longer, on the page, the same person

— and verse 14 then asks how you can call on someone you have not believed in.

THE EVIDENCE

No Greek manuscript of the New Testament contains the Tetragrammaton. The J-references supporting the insertions are Hebrew *translations* of the Greek, the earliest from 1385. The form “Jehovah” is itself a hybrid: the consonants of the divine name with the vowels of *adonai*, not attested before roughly the thirteenth century in Latin transcription. The substitution it is said to correct arose from Second Temple Jewish scribal reverence, not from Christendom.

Their answer. Where the Christian Greek Scriptures quote a Hebrew passage containing the divine name, the name is restored. Romans 10:13 quotes Joel 2:32.

Response. Consistency is the difficulty. Applying that policy here severs an argument the apostle is building across six verses. Where a quotation is used by a New Testament writer to say something about Jesus, restoring the name changes what the passage argues rather than recovering it.

One further point of accuracy. Jason BeDuhn’s *Truth in Translation* (2003) is cited on jw.org as rating the translation highly, and that is a fair report of what he wrote. The same book devotes an appendix to dismantling these insertions as conjectural emendation. jw.org’s own page also notes that his comments concern editions before the 2013 revision. All three of those things are true together.

When did worship become obeisance?

Hebrews 1 is a chain of contrasts. From verse 4 the writer is arguing that the Son is superior to the angels, and at 1:6 he says what the angels are to do when the firstborn is brought into the inhabited earth.

From 1950 through the 1970 printing, your translation said they were to worship him. The 1971 revision changed it to “do obeisance,” and it has read that way since.

The word behind it is used across the Christian Greek Scriptures. When its object is Jehovah, your Bible renders it “worship.” When its object is Jesus at Hebrews 1:6, it renders it “do obeisance.”

The exhibit below runs the opposite way to the Colossians page. Here the word-for-word line under the Greek reads “do obeisance,” while the New World Translation column beside it reads “worship” — both printed on one page, by one publisher, in one year.

There is a second case in Revelation 5:13–14. The One on the throne and the Lamb together are given the blessing, the honour, the glory and the might, and then the elders fall down and worship. Your Bible uses “worship” there. It is fair to say, and the box says it, that the object of that verb is not named in the Greek, so the sentence can be read as worship offered to God alone.

The published answer is that the word covers a wide range of meanings, and that is true. The range raises a different question: if the word genuinely covers that range, what is deciding, each time, which end of the range gets used?

προσκυνήσάτωσαν let do obeisance toward θεοῦ.	αὐτῷ him	πάντες all	ἄγγελοι angels	let all God's angels worship him." 7 Also with refer
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The Kingdom Interlinear Translation of the Greek Scriptures, Watch Tower Bible and Tract Society, 1969, p. 965, at Hebrews 1:6. The word-for-word line reads “let do obeisance toward him all angels of God”; the column beside it reads “let all God’s angels worship him.” Reproduced for criticism and review.

THE EVIDENCE

The verb is προσκυνέω (*proskyneō*). Hebrews 1:6 quotes Deuteronomy 32:43. The dates are worth checking rather than taking on trust: the reading was “worship” from 1950 through the 1970 edition and changed in the 1971 revision — not 1961, which several apologetics sites state incorrectly.

Their answer. The study note at Hebrews 1:6 argues from the breadth of the verb in the standard lexicons: it covers prostration before a superior as well as worship of God, and the context decides which is meant. Of Jesus, the appropriate sense is the honour due to a king.

Response. Breadth is exactly why a translation that varies the word according to the identity of its object is making a doctrinal decision rather than a lexical one. The lexicons permit both senses everywhere; they do not tell you to sort them by who is receiving the action.

Why are the two halves of one verse treated differently?

This is the shortest argument in the document, and it may be the most easily checked.

John 1:18 closes the prologue and closes the argument John has been making since 1:1: that the Word was with God, that no one has seen God, and that the one at the Father's side has explained him.

The verse contains the same Greek word for God twice. Neither occurrence has the definite article in front of it — the little word “the.” The grammatical situation is identical in both halves of one sentence.

Your Bible renders the first one “God”: no man has seen God at any time. It renders the second one “god,” lowercase: the only-begotten god who is at the Father's side.

You cannot see the Greek from the English, but you can see the result, and the result is what matters. One verse. One form of one word, twice. Two different renderings.

This argument sits here rather than earlier because it only bites once you know what the published justification at John 1:1 actually is. The footnote there gives the reason for “a god”: the word appears without the article, in contrast with the same word carrying the article earlier in the sentence. So the rule offered is about the article. John 1:18 is the same translators applying that same situation to two words in one sentence and reaching two answers.

THE EVIDENCE

The word is θεός (*theos*), anarthrous in both places at John 1:18. The New World Translation footnote at John 1:1 states the contrast between *theos* and *ton Theon* explicitly and refers the reader to Appendix 6A.

Their answer. Appendix 6A argues that an anarthrous predicate noun before the verb is qualitative or indefinite rather than definite, and quotes Philip Harner to that effect — that there is no basis for regarding the predicate *theos* as definite.

Response. That is a real quotation and it is not going away, so it should be met rather than avoided. The usable distinction is that qualitative is not indefinite. Harner's reading is that the Word shares the *nature* denoted by *theos*, which tells against "a god" — a distinct being of a lesser class — as sharply as it tells against flatly identifying him with the Father. See Philip B. Harner, "Qualitative Anarthrous Predicate Nouns," *Journal of Biblical Literature* 92 (1973), 75–87.

Colwell's rule is not invoked here. It concerns definite predicate nouns, it is misapplied constantly in popular apologetics, and using it would invite a correction that we would deserve.

A second resting point

The second section is finished.

It asked a different kind of question from the first. Band one asked what the Bible says. This section asked why it says it in the particular words it uses — which is a fair question to ask of any translation, including the ones we use.

Four things came out of it. A phrase God uses about himself is rendered three ways, and the effect is that a close link between Isaiah 43 and John 13 cannot be seen by anyone reading only this translation. A name inserted at Romans 10:13 interrupts an argument Paul is building across six verses. A word that meant worship for twenty years became obeisance in 1971, and still means worship when its object is Jehovah — with the Society's own interlinear printing both renderings on one page. And a single verse in John renders the same word two ways.

None of that is an accusation against anybody. Translators make choices, and every translation has them. What is being asked is only whether these particular choices are ones you would have made, knowing what they do to the passages.

The next section is shorter, and it is about a different subject.

PART TWO

The Spirit, and the three together

*A shorter section, on a different subject, resting
on the same method.*

Who is speaking in Hebrews 10?

Hebrews 10:1-18 argues one thing: that the repeated sacrifices under the Law could not remove sins, and that one sacrifice has.

At the end of that argument, at 10:15, the writer brings in a witness. He says the holy spirit bears witness to us — and then quotes it speaking.

What follows in verses 16 and 17 is Jeremiah 31:33-34: I will put my laws in their hearts, and in their minds I will write them; and I will no longer call their sins to mind.

Look at how your own Bible prints verse 16. Inside the words the holy spirit is said to be speaking, it reads: says Jehovah.

So the sentence, as it stands in the New World Translation, says that the holy spirit spoke, and that the words it spoke are words identifying Jehovah as the speaker.

This is not a claim about Greek and it is not a claim about a disputed reading. It is the plain arrangement of a verse in your own translation — and the divine name at that point is there because the translation committee placed it there, under the policy explained in their own appendix.

Their study note on the verse states the position without hedging: the words are ascribed to God's holy spirit. It also points to Hebrews 3:7, where the same writer does the same thing with Psalm 95 — the holy spirit says, and what follows is God speaking in the first person.

You met this shape once already, in Isaiah 6. This is the second time, and this time it is inside one verse.

THE EVIDENCE

Their answer. The general position, set out in *Awake!* of July 2006, “Is the Holy Spirit a Person?”, is that the spirit is God’s active force and that passages appearing to give it personal action are personification, as wisdom is personified at Luke 7:35 and sin and death at Romans 5. On that reading, the spirit “speaking” means that the message was conveyed by means of it.

Response. Personification explains a figure of speech inside a clause. It does not explain an attribution of authorship, which is what Hebrews is making: the writer needs a witness whose testimony settles the argument, and he names the spirit as that witness. And the difficulty here is one the translation created for itself, since the words attributed to the spirit are the ones in which their own committee inserted the divine name.

What did Peter say Ananias had done?

Acts 5 opens in the middle of a story that begins at 4:32. The Jerusalem congregation is sharing possessions; Barnabas sells a field and hands over the proceeds. Ananias and Sapphira sell property, hold back part of the price, and present the rest as though it were all of it.

Peter's rebuke is two sentences long, and they sit next to each other.

The first, at 5:3: why has Satan emboldened you to lie to the holy spirit? The second, at 5:4, after a short question about whose money it was: you have lied, not to men, but to God.

That is all this argument is. One deception, described twice in consecutive breaths, first as a lie to the holy spirit and then as a lie to God.

The published answer is that the holy spirit is God's active force, and that lying against someone's force or representative amounts to lying to them. That answer is stated in the box, and it is not a foolish one; people do speak that way.

But notice what the passage requires it to carry. Peter is not saying that Ananias lied to the apostles and thereby to God, which would be the natural shape of an argument about representation. He names the holy spirit as the one lied to, and then names God as the one lied to, with nothing between to mark a change of subject.

THE EVIDENCE

Four verses later, at Acts 5:9, the same episode is described again: Peter asks why the two of them agreed to make a test of the spirit of Jehovah.

Their answer. *Awake!*, July 2006, pages 14-15, sets out the active-force position: the spirit is God's power in action, described at Genesis 1:2 and given personal-sounding language by personification. Lying to the spirit is lying to the God who sends it.

Response. Representation would make the sentence read the other way round — lying to men and thereby to God. Peter puts the spirit where the person lied to belongs, and then puts God there. The two clauses are doing the same work.

Can a force decide?

This section gathers several short passages, because no one of them settles anything and together they make a pattern.

Acts 13:2. The congregation at Antioch is worshipping and fasting, and the holy spirit says: set apart for me Barnabas and Saul for the work to which I have called them. The speech is in the first person, and it claims both the calling and the workers.

Acts 15:28. The Jerusalem council issues its decision and words it: the holy spirit and we have favoured. A group of men name the spirit alongside themselves as party to a decision.

1 Corinthians 12:11. The gifts are distributed to each one as the spirit wills. Whatever else is true, that is a sentence about choosing.

Romans 8:26-27. The spirit pleads for us, and God, who searches hearts, knows what the mind of the spirit is.

Ephesians 4:30. Do not be grieving God's holy spirit.

Now the honest part, which belongs here rather than in a footnote. The Christian Greek Scriptures also speak of people being filled with holy spirit in the same breath as being filled with wisdom, or faith, or joy, and they put the spirit alongside water and fire. That is real, it is in the text, and it is the strongest thing that can be said on the other side. It means this argument cannot be run on the word "spirit" in general.

It has to be run on these particular sentences, and on what they describe: speaking in the first person, being party to a

decision, choosing who receives what, having a mind that can be known, and being capable of grief.

THE EVIDENCE

Their answer. The brochure *Should You Believe in the Trinity?*, in the section on the holy spirit as God's active force, argues personification and gives the parallel cases: wisdom with children at Luke 7:35, sin and death reigning as kings at Romans 5:14 and 5:21, sin crouching at Genesis 4:7, and the three witnesses of 1 John 5:6-8. It also observes that people are said to be filled with spirit as they are with wisdom and joy.

Response. Each of those parallels is a figure of speech contained within a single clause, and no reader is expected to carry it further. The passages above are not like that: they report decisions taken, workers claimed, gifts allotted and a mind that God can be said to know.

The argument from the Greek pronoun ἐκεῖνος (*ekeinos*) in John 14-16 is deliberately not used here. See the list at the end.

Into whose name?

Matthew 28:16–20 is the commission at the end of the Gospel. The eleven meet Jesus on the mountain, he tells them that all authority has been given him, and he sends them to make disciples, baptising them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the holy spirit.

The whole argument here is available in the English you already have, and it is one word: name, singular.

Not names. One name, spread across three.

Then ask what baptism into a name means, using the Bible's own usage. To be baptised into someone's name is to be brought into allegiance and belonging — Paul objects at 1 Corinthians 1:13 to the very idea of anyone being baptised into his. It is a relationship word.

The published answer is that the formula is about recognising the authority and the role of each, and that recognising a role is not the same as worshipping a person. That is fair as far as it reaches, and it is stated in the box.

Where it strains is the third item. Recognising the Father's authority makes sense. Recognising the Son's role makes sense. Being baptised into the name of an impersonal force does not have an obvious meaning, and the published answer does not supply one.

THE EVIDENCE

The Greek has one noun, ὄνομα (*onoma*), singular, governing three coordinated genitives. That is support for the argument rather than the argument itself, which runs perfectly well on the English.

Their answer. The study note on Matthew 28:19 explains the phrase as acknowledging the authority of the Father, the position of the Son and the operation of the holy spirit, and cites a Bible encyclopaedia to the effect that being baptised into a name means recognising that name's authority.

Response. Accepted for the first two items. The third is where the explanation runs out: to acknowledge the operation of a force is an odd thing to place, grammatically and conceptually, alongside allegiance to a person and to his Son, in a single name.

One God, and three named

This last section has to begin with a concession, because the standard argument for it is weak and you have probably already met the answer.

The weak argument is a list. Matthew 28:19, 2 Corinthians 13:14, Ephesians 4:4-6, 1 Peter 1:2 and the scene at Jesus' baptism in Matthew 3:16-17 all name the three together. The Watchtower's reply is that mentioning three things together proves nothing about them, and it points to 1 Timothy 5:21, where God, Christ and the chosen angels are named in one breath. That reply is correct. Lists do not prove anything, and this document is not going to pretend otherwise.

So the weight goes somewhere else: onto 1 Corinthians 8:6, and onto what Paul does with it.

Read Deuteronomy 6:4 first. It is the sentence every Jewish child learned: Jehovah our God is one Jehovah. Two words carry it — God, and the divine name.

Now read 1 Corinthians 8:6, in a chapter about food offered to idols where Paul has just said that there is no God but one. He writes: there is one God, the Father, from whom all things are — and one Lord, Jesus Christ, through whom all things are.

Paul has taken the confession of one God, expanded it into two clauses, kept "one" on both, and placed Jesus inside it rather than beside it. He does this in the middle of an argument for monotheism, not in spite of one.

That is the shape the rest of this document has been describing. Not three Gods, and not one God wearing three

costumes: one God, with the Son and the Spirit named inside the confession rather than outside it.

THE EVIDENCE

In the Septuagint of Deuteronomy 6:4 the divine name is represented by κύριος (*kyrios*), Lord — the word Paul assigns to Jesus at 1 Corinthians 8:6, while assigning *theos* to the Father. Both halves of the confession are accounted for and neither is left over.

Their answer. 1 Corinthians 8:6 is read as drawing the distinction rather than closing it: the Father alone is called the one God, and Jesus is the one Lord through whom things come, which marks him as the agent and not the source. On the wider point, *Reasoning From the Scriptures* and the *Trinity* brochure argue that texts naming three together state neither equality nor shared divinity.

Response. The reply to the list argument is granted above, without reservation. On 8:6, the difficulty is that Paul is not adding a second figure alongside the confession but distributing the confession's own two terms. If "one Lord" marks Jesus out as something less, the same logic makes the Shema's Lord something less, which no one holds.

The end of the document

This section did the smaller half of the job. Most of what came before was about one question — whether the Christian Greek Scriptures treat Jesus as God — and this part asked what those same writers do with the holy spirit, and what happens when all three appear together.

It showed a speech attributed to the holy spirit whose words name Jehovah as the speaker; a single deception called both a lie to the spirit and a lie to God; sentences in which the spirit speaks in the first person, joins a decision, chooses, has a mind and can be grieved; a baptism into one name held by three; and Paul writing Jesus into the confession that there is only one God.

It is worth saying plainly what has not been shown. This document has not proved a creed, and it has not tried to. Creeds came later and were written in words the Bible does not use. What has been set out is what the texts themselves do, in the translation you already trust.

Two things follow. The first is the list of arguments we did not use, and why. The second is a longer technical section for anyone who wants the Greek, the manuscripts and the disputed readings worked through properly.

Arguments we are not using, and why

Almost no document of this kind prints this section. It is here because a case that shows you only its best material is not a case. Each of these is used regularly by people arguing our side, and each was dropped.

Jude 5. The manuscripts divide between Jesus, Lord and God. The reading “Jesus” has better attestation; “Lord” fits the context better; the editors rate the decision as highly uncertain. The New World Translation has legitimate grounds here, so the verse is not used.

1 John 5:7, the three heavenly witnesses. Not original. Whatever it proves, it is not evidence.

1 Timothy 3:16. The critical text reads “who” rather than “God.” The argument runs the other way from the one usually made with it.

John 1:18 as a manuscript argument. The reading “only-begotten God” is probably original, but establishing that needs the apparatus. The rendering argument in this document is a different point and stands on its own.

John 14:14. The editors bracket the word that would make it “ask me,” a copying error is a live explanation, and John 15:16 and 16:23 point the other way.

The Greek pronoun for the Spirit in John 14-16. It can agree grammatically with the noun for helper rather than indicating a person. Even scholars who hold our conclusion concede this.

Capitalising “Holy One.” Hebrew has no capitals and the Greek manuscripts are written in one case throughout. Any capital letter in any English Bible is a translator’s decision.

“Holy One” and “Saviour” used alone. Psalm 106:16 calls Aaron a holy one, and Judges 3:9 and 3:15 call human deliverers saviours. Neither title carries an argument by itself.

Philippians 2:9 and the word “other.” The New World Translation does read “every other name” here. But the phrase is comparative in the Greek, and at least one mainstream translation renders it the same way. Treating every inserted “other” as doctrinal would be unfair, and this is the case that shows why.

2 Corinthians 3:17. Their translation prints that Jehovah is the Spirit, which looks striking. It establishes nothing about personhood, and “God is a spirit” answers it in one line.

1 Corinthians 2:10-11. Paul compares the Spirit of God to a man’s own spirit, and a man’s spirit is not a second person. The analogy cuts both ways.

The edition history of the brackets at Colossians 1:16. Widely circulated, and the sources contradict one another about which printings carried brackets. We can show you the 1969 page and the 2013 text, so that is all we claim.

Colwell’s rule. It addresses a different question from the one it is usually cited for, and using it would invite a correction we would deserve.

Anything about the men. The 1954 court testimony, the anonymity of the committee, speculation about motive. The textual arguments carry the case alone, and they should.

The claim that no scholar defends the New World Translation. False. jw.org cites Jason BeDuhn, accurately, and a reader who discovers that after reading a document claiming otherwise is right to discount the whole thing.

If any citation in this document is wrong — a page number, an edition, a rendering — it should be said, and it will be corrected. The contact route is below.

Two further documents, and no obligation to read either

You have reached the end of the case. Nothing further is required of you, and nothing here asks you to contact anyone, attend anything, or make a decision by a date.

The technical appendix. Nine further arguments that need Greek, a manuscript judgement, or a disputed reading weighed: John 1:1 and the rule the footnote states; Revelation 3:14; Hebrews 1:8; Philippians 2:6; Colossians 2:9; Acts 20:28; 1 Peter 1:11; the shared throne in Daniel 7 and Revelation 22; the Isaiah 43 pattern in John 6 and John 13; and the chain of “I am” sayings. They are separated out because they ask more of the reader, not because they are weaker. Several are stronger.

A second document, on a different subject. This one has been about translation and about what the texts say. The other is about the record of the organisation that published your Bible: what was taught about 1914, 1925 and 1975, what happened, and what was published afterwards. It is a harder document to read than this one and it is deliberately placed last. If you would rather not, that is a reasonable choice and this document stands without it.

Every reference in this document can be checked in your own Bible, your own interlinear, or the Society’s own online library. That was the point of writing it this way.